

EYEWITNESS 1967

A Black American Soldier

Racial discrimination was deeply ingrained in American society. As a result, life for Black soldiers differed greatly from their white counterparts—in terms of experience, opportunities, and dangers. Haywood T. Kirkland, a GI, described how Black soldiers banded together in the face of racism, both in Vietnam and upon returning home.

Racialism was apparent in the base-camp area. Kirkland described rebel flags flying from jeeps and how it made him feel insulted and intimidated. He noted that, often branded troublemakers, Black soldiers were sent to the fields, even those who had supply clerk or cook military specialties, while the white soldiers usually got jobs as supply clerks or in the mess hall.

This led the Black soldiers at the base camp to close ranks and become more organized as a group. They began to discuss being part of the struggle of Black people and how Vietnam was doing nothing for it. When Kirkland returned home, the reaction of his peers who questioned why he had gone to war led to him developing a more revolutionary, militant attitude, the seeds of which had been laid back in Vietnam.

“They killed Dr. King just before I came home. I felt used.”

HAYWOOD T. “THE KID” KIRKLAND, INTERVIEWED IN *BLOODS: AN ORAL HISTORY OF THE VIETNAM WAR BY BLACK VETERANS*, 1984